Letter of Information and Consent

Project Title: Creating a Drug Checking Network Using Machine Learning Enabled Spectrometers

Principal Investigator (PI): Professor Francois Lagugne-Labarthet, Faculty of Science, Western University, London, ON, Canada. 519-661-2111 x81006 – flagugne@uwo.ca

Dear Prospective Participant,

We are inviting you to participate in a research study conducted by Dr. Francois Lagugne-Labarthet and Dr. Abe Oudshoorn of Western University. This project will provide voluntary drug-testing to clients of healthcare organizations across Canada who offer such services.

Participants must be 18 years of age or older and have 0.5mg of substance or greater for testing.

What is the purpose of the study?

The purpose of this study is to give Canadians data regarding drug consumption. Currently, there is very limited access to drug-checking across Canada for people who use drugs (PWUD). The lack of drug-checking services leads to people consuming substances that they do not intend to consume such as fentanyl and its analogs. This leads to accidental overdoses and deaths. We want to understand both what drugs are being consumed in Canada, but more importantly, how learning about what is in your sample might impact decisions you make around using. This is currently taking place at more than 20 sites across Canada, and we will conduct 24,000-65,000 drug tests.

What will I do?

Your sample test will take either 5 minutes (short scan) or 15 minutes (long scan). The length of the scan means basically how detailed a view we take of your sample. This effects how precise we can be in terms of understanding exactly what is in your sample and in what amount. (In technical terms, the scan is using spectroscopy and a short scan uses 625 spectra whereas a long scan uses 2500 spectra.) While you wait for your drug test result we will ask you some demographic questions. It's your choice to answer these or not. When the result comes back, you can learn about what is in your sample and then we will ask if you will still be using this sample today, delaying use, reducing use, or choosing not to use the substance. Please note that the results are not 100% guaranteed and there is a small possibility of false positives or false negatives and the findings are not necessarily conclusive. If not using the substance, we will request your permission to send this to Western University in London Ontario for detailed analysis. The results of this analysis will be returned here for you to pick up if you wish. Western University may also send part of some samples on to Health Canada's Drug Analysis Service for extra confirmation testing. Choosing to participate or not today will not affect your access to other services here at the site.

What are the risks and benefits of the study?

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There are risks to anonymity associated with the study. This includes the possibility that a worker unintentionally records identifying information about you. In order to prevent this, the device will delete a scan from the database if it contains a name, email, phone number, or address.

Secondly, we acknowledge that the information provided from the scan can put you in a tough situation to make choices about your use. Your harm reduction worker can't counsel you regarding what is in your test, but can provide you information about substances and substance use.

A final risk is that you may overdose after participating in the drug checking. Whether or not a controlled substance is detected by the device, your results will include a statement clarifying that the risk of consuming an unknown sample can result in adverse side effects, overdose, or death.

Can I withdraw from the study?

Yes, you may withdraw from the study at any time prior to publication of the findings without negative consequences. If you would like to completely remove your data from the study, you can do so by asking a site worker who will forward this request to the lead researcher for deletion of your data.

Compensation

There is no compensation for participation in this study.

Is the study voluntary and confidential?

Participation in this study is completely voluntary. The research team will strive to maintain privacy and confidentiality. You will not be required to provide any directly identifiable information such as your name or date of birth. With your permission, we will record your gender, age, racial/ethnic identity, preferred language, and if you identify as LGBTQ or another minority sexual orientation or gender identity. These will only be reported all together for all participants at a site, not individually.

Western University Health Sciences Research Ethics Board and representatives may access study materials for monitoring purposes.

Your data from the scan device database will be provided electronically to the Western researchers named above for analysis. This research data will be stored for 7 years post-publication, and subsequently deleted.

Results of the Study

Results of the scans will be shared monthly in a report to each site. The results of the study may be published in scholarly journals, presented at research conferences, and shared with relevant

stakeholders in the health sector. The results will also be shared in a report the project funder, Health Canada.

Conflict of Interest

The testing devices are created by a company called Scatr. The study researchers have no conflict of interest in the work and no financial relationship to Scatr. Scatr has no on-site involvement in regard to data collection. All will be done by the site workers who have no conflict of interest. Additionally, Scatr is not doing the data analysis or generating the site reports. Data is simply being provided to the research team who will do the analysis and dissemination of results independently.

As the developer of the drug testing device, Scatr may financially benefit from the results of the study.

Consent

Providing your sample for testing is indication of your consent to participate.

Dr. Lagugne-Labarthet and/or others intend to claim sole ownership of any research results consistent with this consent. By consenting to this study, you agree that Dr. Lagugne-Labarthet can apply for patents and you will not receive any financial benefit that might come from the research.

For More Information:

Western University Health Sciences Research Ethics Board (HSREB) requires access to the study records to monitor the conduct of this research. Please contact the Office of Human Research ethics if you have questions or concerns about your rights as a participant and/or the conduct of this study.

Phone: (519) 661-3036

Email: ethics@uwo.ca

Please contact Dr. Lagugne-Labarthet, the Principal Investigator, with any questions pertaining to the study, including the purpose and participant requirements.

Phone: 519-661-2111 x81006

Email: flagugne@uwo.ca

Sincerely,

Professor Francois Lagugne-Labarthet

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Western University

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